

In these final weeks, your baby continues to lay down insulating fat deposits for life outside of the uterus, and the lungs are ready to take their first breath. Your baby will settle into his final position, ready for the birth.

33 WEEKS Each day, your baby is preparing for survival in the outside world.



Baby watch

📏 17% in (45 cm) 📖 4 lb 11½ oz (2.1 kg)

Your baby is increasingly awake and active, and is becoming more aware of her surroundings, as she touches her face and pulls on the umbilical cord. Her sucking reflex is strong enough now that if born this early, she should be able to feed independently. Her fingernails are reaching the tips of her nail beds, and may need a trim at birth.

Mom matters

Your heart works extra hard now as you approach the home stretch—your heart rate increases by 10 to 15 beats a minute and the heart works up to 50 percent harder. It's not uncommon to experience fluttery palpitations; these are usually harmless, though mention them to your doctor if accompanied by breathlessness or chest pain.



This week...

- » Regularly massaging your perineum can help make this area more supple and reduces your risk of tearing during the delivery.
- » Start thinking about who will give support once the baby is here, and also in the future.

34 WEEKS Practicing relaxation techniques will help you prepare for labor.



Baby watch

📏 18% in (46.2 cm) 📖 5 lb 5 oz (2.4 kg)

Your baby looks far more in proportion, and is nicely plump. In the limbs, the bones continue to harden. Waste from the amniotic fluid is building up in the gut, forming a sticky substance called meconium, which will be your baby's first greenish-black poop after the birth.

Mom matters

Your baby is most likely to be lying vertically by this stage of pregnancy, though occasionally, babies are in a diagonal or horizontal position. As your baby gets bigger, her movements are likely to feel stronger, more frequent, and have a recognizable pattern now rather than seeming like isolated kicks.



This week...

- » If you have an older child, have someone lined up to watch her when you go to the hospital.
- » Pack your hospital bag and keep your birth plan on hand. Make sure your partner knows where everything is too.

35 WEEKS Your body is well and truly gearing up for the big day.



Baby watch

📏 18% in (47.4 cm) 📖 5 lb 10 oz (2.6 kg)

Your baby may have stationed herself in a head-down position, ready for her exit later this month. She is still busy laying down fat to insulate her after birth. At the same time, she will shed her lanugo hair, and may have just a few patches left over the back and shoulders.

Mom matters

With labor approaching, your baby's head may begin to "engage" (descend into your pelvis), and your belly may sit lower. The release of pressure on the diaphragm makes it easier to breathe. This is known as "lightening." The baby's head now presses on your bladder, which means frequent bathroom stops and interrupted sleep. Aches and pains in the pelvic area may well increase.



This week...

- » Get fitted for a nursing bra now and get equipped for breast-feeding.
- » Prepare instructions for those filling in for you at work if you're starting maternity leave.
- » Keep practicing your Kegel exercises regularly to avoid stress incontinence later.

36 WEEKS Make sure you have a plan ready for when you go into labor.



Baby watch

📏 19% in (48.6 cm) 📖 6 lb 5 oz (2.9 kg)

Your baby is almost full term, and her lungs are fully developed now, which means she could breathe without help if born from this point. She is losing the waxy vernix, though some may linger at birth.

Mom matters

Braxton Hicks contractions may be occurring with increasing regularity, and production of the hormone relaxin increases, helping to relax the pelvic ligaments and to soften the cervix. A combination of hormonal surges, anxiety about labor, lack of sleep, and aches and pains may leave you feeling a little vulnerable. Mood swings are quite common in these final weeks.



This week...

- » Keep an eye on the strength and pattern of your baby's movements and report any changes to your doctor.
- » Learn about the signs of labor so that you know what to expect, and feel confident about when to call your doctor.
- » Finalize your birth plan.